

A PRACTICAL STARTER GUIDE • PAKISTAN

10 BUSINESS IDEAS

FOR PAKISTANIS

START SMALL. INVEST SMART.
BUILD YOUR OWN INCOME.

10 beginner-friendly business models with low starter budgets, practical steps and realistic example calculations.

A practical guide • Figures in Pakistani Rupees (PKR)

BEFORE YOU START

You don't need a large office, expensive equipment or thousands of followers to test a small business. Some ideas in this guide can begin with a smartphone, basic supplies and the willingness to approach your first customers.

HOW TO READ THE NUMBERS

- Budgets and prices are planning estimates in Pakistani rupees. Actual costs vary by city, supplier, quality and date.
- The Rs. 5,000 target refers to starter cash—not the value of equipment you may already own.
- Some ideas require an existing smartphone, kitchen, freezer, water source or transport. These requirements are stated in the relevant chapter.
- Monthly examples are illustrations, not promises. They assume you have found the stated number of paying customers.
- "Remaining amount" is an estimate after the listed operating costs, but before tax, unexpected losses and a formal salary for your own time.

A SIMPLE RULE

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

Test demand before buying stock. Your first goal is one paying customer—not a perfect logo, expensive equipment or a large social media following.

CHOOSE THE RIGHT IDEA

Choose an idea that fits your available tools, skills, time and neighbourhood. If an idea depends on equipment you do not own, calculate that extra cost before starting. Keep the first version small and improve it after real customer feedback.

A NOTE ON BUSINESS COMPLIANCE

Food businesses, tax obligations, consumer protection, local permissions and other requirements may apply depending on the activity and location. Check current local rules before trading. Frozen-food sellers must pay particular attention to food hygiene, safe storage, labelling and applicable Sindh Food Authority requirements.

BUSINESS IDEA 01

Product Photography for Small Businesses

Turn a smartphone into a simple product-photography service.

Small online sellers need clear product pictures for social media and catalogues. Offer clean, accurate images using natural light and a simple background.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Basic phone tripod	Rs. 1,000
White background board/sheet	Rs. 400
Reflector / white foam board	Rs. 300
Simple props	Rs. 800
Cleaning and misc.	Rs. 500
TOTAL	Rs. 3,000

Important assumption: You already own a smartphone with a usable camera. Start with daylight; a studio is not required.

HOW TO START

- Choose one category: clothing, jewellery, cosmetics or food.
- Create a small shooting area near a window with indirect daylight.
- Photograph 8–10 sample products from useful angles.
- Edit cropping and brightness without changing the product's real colour.
- Agree on image count, delivery time and revisions before accepting payment.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

5 images: Rs. 700–1,000 • 10 images: Rs. 1,200–1,800 • 15 images: Rs. 1,800–2,500. Treat these as starter offers, not fixed market rates.

> ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE
>
> **8 packages × Rs. 1,500 = Rs. 12,000 sales. Less Rs. 2,000 estimated travel, props and other costs = Rs. 10,000 remaining. This assumes eight completed paid orders.**

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Approach small Instagram stores, clothing sellers, jewellery shops and Facebook Marketplace sellers. Show a sample portfolio and offer a small paid trial.

Growth tip: Offer monthly image packages to customers who need regular product updates.

BUSINESS IDEA 02

Customized Gift Packaging Studio

Make ordinary gifts look thoughtful and ready to-present.

Offer gift wrapping, ribbons, decorative boxes and personalized packaging for birthdays, weddings, graduations and other occasions.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Basic gift boxes	Rs. 1,000
Wrapping sheets	Rs. 500
Ribbons and bows	Rs. 500
Filler / decorative material	Rs. 500
Scissors, tape and glue	Rs. 500
Samples and extras	Rs. 500
TOTAL	Rs. 3,500

Important assumption: Buy supplies in small quantities. Charge separately for expensive boxes and special materials.

HOW TO START

- Create three samples: simple, birthday and decorative.
- Photograph each sample clearly.
- Offer packaging for customer-provided gifts.
- Confirm gift size, occasion, colours and budget before quoting.
- Take an advance for customized or costly materials.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Simple wrapping: Rs. 250–400 • Decorative packaging: Rs. 500–800 • Gift-box arrangement: Rs. 900–1,500+.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

15 orders × Rs. 800 = Rs. 12,000 sales. Less Rs. 6,000 materials and Rs. 1,000 other costs = Rs. 5,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Show samples to friends, relatives, students, gift shops and local social-media sellers. Ask a nearby gift shop about referrals.

Growth tip: Create seasonal collections for Eid, weddings and graduation season.

Short-Form Video Creation

Make simple promotional videos for local businesses.

Local shops often need short vertical videos for Reels, TikTok, Facebook and WhatsApp. Offer basic recording and editing with a smartphone.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Phone tripod	Rs. 1,000
Basic microphone	Rs. 1,200
Small light	Rs. 800
Internet and misc.	Rs. 700
TOTAL	Rs. 3,700

Important assumption: You already own a suitable smartphone. Natural light can replace a light at the beginning; a microphone can be added later.

HOW TO START

- Learn basic cuts, captions and audio timing in a beginner editing app.
- Choose a category such as restaurants, clothing or salons.
- Create three sample videos with permission to film.
- Agree on length, revisions, delivery date and usage rights.
- Send a preview and collect payment under agreed terms.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

One simple video: Rs. 500–800 • 3 videos: Rs. 1,500–2,000 • 8-video starter package: Rs. 3,500–5,000.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

4 clients × Rs. 3,500 = Rs. 14,000 sales. Less Rs. 2,500 internet, travel and other costs = Rs. 11,500 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Visit nearby restaurants, clothing stores, cafés and salons. Show one relevant sample and explain exactly what the package includes.

Growth tip: Move repeat customers to monthly content packages.

BUSINESS IDEA 04

Small Birthday Decoration Service

Begin with compact home setups—not expensive event production.

Families may want a decorated corner at home. Offer a small balloon arrangement, banner and simple backdrop that one person can carry and assemble.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Balloon packs	Rs. 1,000
Manual balloon pump	Rs. 400
Tape and glue dots	Rs. 400
Birthday banner	Rs. 400
Ribbons / decoration	Rs. 600
Miscellaneous	Rs. 500
TOTAL	Rs. 3,300

Important assumption: Start with compact designs. Event-specific or expensive materials should be covered by a customer advance.

HOW TO START

- Practise three simple designs and photograph them.
- Offer a small home-birthday package.
- Confirm location, theme, colours, timing and budget.
- Take a booking advance for special materials.
- Include transport and setup time in your quote.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Basic balloon corner: Rs. 1,500–2,000 • Standard small setup: Rs. 2,500–3,500 • Customized setup: quote by materials and labour.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

4 setups × Rs. 2,500 = Rs. 10,000 sales. Less Rs. 5,500 materials/transport and Rs. 500 other costs = Rs. 4,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Show samples to relatives, parent groups, local photographers and cake shops. Ask satisfied customers to share event photos.

Growth tip: Reinvest in reusable stands and backdrops before buying lots of one-use decorations.

Chocolate and Money Bouquets

Create personalised gifts for celebrations and special occasions.

Assemble bouquets using wrapping sheets, ribbons, decorative sticks and customer-selected chocolates. Keep the chocolate cost separate from your assembly charge.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Wrapping sheets	Rs. 500
Ribbons and bows	Rs. 400
Sticks and basic tools	Rs. 400
Decorative flowers	Rs. 600
Sample chocolates	Rs. 1,200
Miscellaneous	Rs. 500
TOTAL	Rs. 3,600

Important assumption: For money bouquets, the customer supplies the currency notes or funds their full value separately. The notes are not your business income.

HOW TO START

- Create two sample chocolate bouquets.
- Photograph them from different angles.
- Offer colour and size choices.
- Confirm chocolate brands and quantities before quoting.
- Take an advance for customized orders.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Small bouquet: Rs. 800–1,200 • Medium: Rs. 1,500–2,000 • Large customized: Rs. 2,500+.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

10 orders × Rs. 1,500 = Rs. 15,000 sales. Less Rs. 10,000 chocolates/materials and Rs. 1,000 other costs = Rs. 4,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Promote samples in WhatsApp groups, Instagram stories, university communities and gift-related local groups.

Growth tip: Offer graduation, birthday and Eid collections with advance booking.

Homemade Frozen Snacks Supply

Start with one snack and small batches for nearby customers.

Prepare one product—such as samosas or spring rolls—and sell it in labelled packs. Test demand before preparing larger quantities.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Ingredients for test batch	Rs. 1,500
Food-safe packaging	Rs. 500
Labels and marker	Rs. 200
Cleaning / hygiene supplies	Rs. 500
Extra-material reserve	Rs. 500
TOTAL	Rs. 3,200

Important assumption: Only suitable if you already have a suitable kitchen, basic utensils and a working freezer. Buying these from scratch exceeds this starter budget.

HOW TO START

- Standardize one recipe and calculate its full batch cost.
- Prepare a small test batch and record yield.
- Use clean food-safe packaging and date labels.
- Keep raw and ready-to-eat food separate; maintain safe freezing and delivery temperatures.
- Check applicable food-business licensing, registration and labelling rules before selling.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Example only: if one pack costs Rs. 350 to make, a test price might be Rs. 450–500. Include energy, delivery, wastage and labour when calculating profit.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

40 packs × Rs. 475 = Rs. 19,000 sales. Less Rs. 14,000 direct ingredients/packaging and Rs. 2,000 other costs = Rs. 3,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Start with nearby households and trusted neighbours. Confirm orders before production and explain storage instructions.

Growth tip: Use fixed weekly delivery days and build repeat orders. Do not produce large speculative stock.

Doorstep Motorcycle Washing

Offer a convenient basic wash within a small neighbourhood.

Motorcycle owners may value a simple wash at home or work. Keep the service area small and confirm water access before accepting a booking.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Cleaning brushes	Rs. 400
Microfiber cloths	Rs. 500
Motorcycle-safe shampoo	Rs. 600
Buckets and spray bottle	Rs. 700
Gloves and misc.	Rs. 500
Local promotion	Rs. 300
TOTAL	Rs. 3,000

Important assumption: You have access to a suitable water source and a way to reach customers.

HOW TO START

- Practise on your own motorcycle.
- Offer a basic exterior wash and a detailed option.
- Confirm water access and safe parking space.
- Use separate cloths for different surfaces.
- Avoid spraying electrical parts, air intakes, bearings or other sensitive areas; avoid harsh chemicals.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Basic wash: Rs. 150–200 • Detailed wash: Rs. 250–300. Check nearby competitors and account for travel and water costs.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

3 bikes/day × Rs. 200 × 20 days = Rs. 12,000 sales. Less Rs. 3,000 supplies, travel and other costs = Rs. 9,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Approach neighbours, apartment residents, shopkeepers and local motorcycle groups. Offer a limited introductory rate.

Growth tip: Offer weekly or monthly repeat-cleaning plans.

Used Books Buying and Selling

Connect book owners with students and readers looking for affordable copies.

Start as a commission-based seller. This reduces the need to spend your small budget buying inventory before you know what sells.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Local promotion	Rs. 300
Internet / communication	Rs. 300
Transport reserve	Rs. 800
Basic packaging	Rs. 300
Miscellaneous	Rs. 300
TOTAL	Rs. 2,000

Important assumption: Use a commission agreement with the book owner. Avoid purchasing costly stock at the beginning.

HOW TO START

- Contact students, graduates and book owners.
- Collect clear photos, edition details and condition.
- Check for missing pages and heavy markings.
- Agree the owner's minimum price and your commission.
- Confirm payment and safe handover arrangements.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Example: negotiate a disclosed Rs. 150 commission for each completed sale. Actual commission depends on book type and agreement.

> **ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE**
>
> **30 sales × Rs. 150 = Rs. 4,500 commission income. Less Rs. 1,500 transport and communication = Rs. 3,000 remaining.**

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Start with students, teachers, tuition centres and local reading groups. Ask each seller for referrals.

Growth tip: Specialize in school textbooks, entry-test books or university course books.

Laundry and Ironing Pickup

Coordinate orders with an existing laundry instead of buying machines.

Collect garments from customers, coordinate with a reliable nearby laundry or ironing shop, and return completed orders. Your income comes from a negotiated margin or a disclosed pickup fee.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Reusable collection bags	Rs. 500
Labels and marker	Rs. 200
Local promotion	Rs. 300
Transport reserve	Rs. 1,200
Miscellaneous	Rs. 300
TOTAL	Rs. 2,500

Important assumption: First negotiate partner rates, turnaround times and responsibility for damaged or missing garments. The example below assumes a Rs. 30 margin per item.

HOW TO START

- Find a reliable laundry or ironing partner.
- Agree rates and service standards in writing.
- Record every customer's garment count and condition.
- Label each bag and keep customer orders separate.
- Start in one neighbourhood with fixed pickup days.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Illustration: partner charges Rs. 70 per item and customer pays Rs. 100. Gross margin: Rs. 30 before your transport and other costs.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

200 garments × Rs. 30 = Rs. 6,000 gross margin. Less Rs. 2,000 transport/other costs = Rs. 4,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Approach apartment buildings, working households, students and small offices. Offer a predictable weekly pickup schedule.

Growth tip: Keep routes short and build repeat customers; excessive travel can erase your margin.

School Project and Model-Making

Offer creative project support,materials and guided assembly.

Students may need help planning charts, display boards and simple models. Support learning and presentation; do not misrepresent work that students are required to complete independently.

STARTER BUDGET

STARTER ITEM	EST. COST
Cardboard and chart paper	Rs. 500
Glue and tape	Rs. 400
Paints and brushes	Rs. 600
Scissors and basic tools	Rs. 500
Decorative materials	Rs. 700
Miscellaneous	Rs. 300
TOTAL	Rs. 3,000

Important assumption: Start with simple projects and buy materials only after confirming the requirements.

HOW TO START

- Create three sample projects of different difficulty.
- Photograph samples clearly.
- List materials and time required for each design.
- Ask for the teacher's instructions before quoting.
- Agree on design, budget, deadline and the student's role.

SUGGESTED BEGINNER PRICING

Simple chart/display: Rs. 300–500 • Basic 3D model: Rs. 700–1,000 • Detailed model: Rs. 1,200–1,800+.

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

10 orders × Rs. 900 = Rs. 9,000 sales. Less Rs. 4,500 materials/transport and Rs. 500 other costs = Rs. 4,000 remaining.

FIND YOUR FIRST 5 CUSTOMERS

Approach parents, tuition centres, teachers, stationery shops and neighbourhood families. Show samples before project season.

Growth tip: Offer material kits and guided assembly sessions as an alternative to doing the student's work.

YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

You don’t need to launch all ten ideas. Choose one that fits your resources, skills and local demand.

WEEK 1 — RESEARCH AND PREPARE

- Choose one idea and check local competitors.
- Calculate your actual starter costs.
- Speak to at least five potential customers.
- Prepare one sample or demonstration.

WEEK 2 — BUILD YOUR OFFER

- Decide exactly what is included.
- Set a price that covers all costs.
- Photograph your sample clearly.
- Create a simple WhatsApp Business profile or social page.

WEEK 3 — FIND PAYING CUSTOMERS

- Contact at least five prospects each day.
- Visit nearby businesses where relevant.
- Share samples in appropriate local groups.
- Try to secure your first paid order.

WEEK 4 — REVIEW AND IMPROVE

- Record every sale and expense.
- Ask customers for honest feedback.
- Identify what attracted genuine interest.
- Improve the offer before spending more.

THE FIRST TARGET

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

Get one paying customer, deliver well, record the real costs, and learn. Repeat only after you understand whether the work is worth doing.

FIVE RULES FOR BEGINNERS

1. Start with what you already have.

Do not buy expensive equipment before testing demand.

2. Separate business and personal money.

Record every rupee received and spent.

3. Do not confuse sales with profit.

Rs. 10,000 in sales minus Rs. 7,000 in costs leaves Rs. 3,000—not Rs. 10,000.

4. Build trust before scaling.

Use clear prices, honest descriptions, timely delivery and good communication.

5. Reinvest carefully.

Improve tools and marketing from actual profit; keep a reserve for unexpected costs.

A FINAL WORD

You do not need to become successful overnight. Take a sensible first step, learn from real customers and improve with every order. A small business may begin with one customer, one product or one simple service. What matters is delivering something useful, charging fairly and managing money responsibly.

START SMALL. LEARN QUICKLY. BUILD STEADILY.

ABOUT THE FIGURES

The budgets, prices and monthly examples in this ebook are illustrative planning estimates, not verified quotations from every Pakistani city or supplier. Costs change with location, season, inflation, product quality and order size. Before accepting an order, obtain current supplier quotes and calculate the actual cost of materials, packaging, transport, utilities, wastage, platform fees and your time.

HOW TO CALCULATE YOUR OWN PROFIT

ILLUSTRATIVE MONTHLY EXAMPLE

Sales revenue – direct materials – delivery/transport – operating costs – wastage/returns = estimated operating profit before tax and other obligations.

CHECK LOCAL REQUIREMENTS

Business registration, tax, consumer-protection, municipal and sector-specific rules may apply. Food businesses must pay particular attention to hygiene, safe storage, labelling and applicable provincial food-authority requirements. Check the current official requirements for your location before selling.

IMPORTANT

This guide is educational material. It does not guarantee earnings, replace professional financial or legal advice, or promise that a business will succeed. Results depend on demand, execution, competition, costs and the time available to the owner.

END OF GUIDE